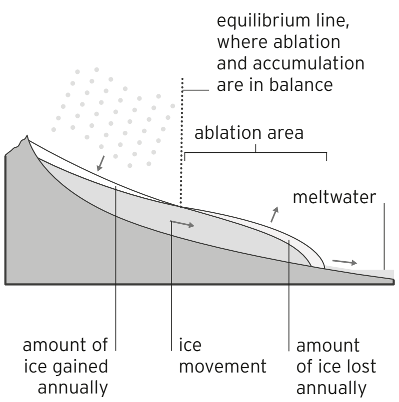
GLOSSARY

A

A'A LAVA Basaltic lava with a rough surface of broken lava blocks or clinker. See also *block lava, pahoehoe lava*.

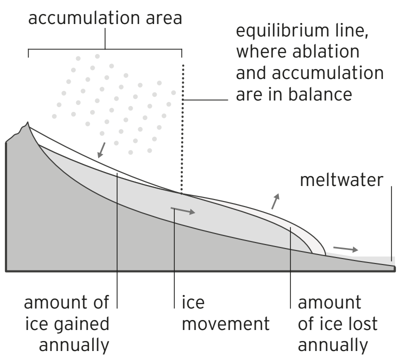
ABLATION ▼ The loss of ice from a glacier due to melting, evaporation, sublimation, calving, or erosion by the wind. The ablation area is the region of a glacier where there is a net loss of ice due to these processes. See also *accumulation area*.



ABYSSAL Referring to the deep ocean floor and its environment, beyond the continental slopes. The abyssal zone is the part of the water column between a depth of 6,600 ft (2,000 m) and the abyssal plain. It is deeper than the bathyal zone but not as deep as the deep-sea trenches. See also *bathyal, deep-sea trench*.

ABYSSAL PLAIN The relatively flat, sediment-covered plain that forms the bed of most of the oceans, beyond the continental slopes. It lies at a depth of 13,000–20,000 ft (4,000–6,000 m). See also *continental slope*.

ACCUMULATION AREA ▼ The part of a glacier where snowfall exceeds losses by melting, evaporation, sublimation, calving, and wind erosion. See also *ablation.*



ACID RAIN Precipitation (rain or snow) containing dissolved acids. Since it contains carbon dioxide, most rain is slightly acidic, but atmospheric pollution or the gases released by volcanic eruptions can make rain more acidic.

ADVECTION FOG A kind of fog that forms as moist air passes over cooler surfaces. It can form over land or the ocean. See also *radiation fog*.

AEROSOL A tiny particle suspended in the air. It may be dust or liquid, and is usually no larger than one millionth of a millimeter in diameter.

AIR MASS A body of air with relatively uniform characteristics derived from the surface region where it forms and distinct from surrounding air masses. Examples include polar maritime and tropical maritime air masses.

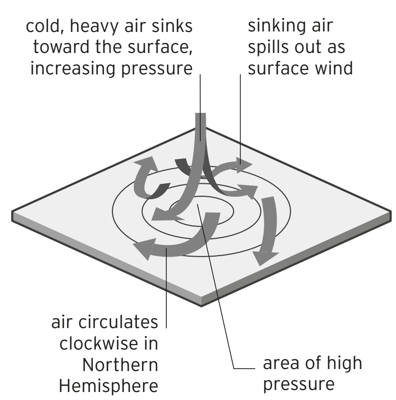
ALBEDO The proportion of the Sun's incoming radiation reflected by Earth's surface. For example, fresh snow may reflect up to 90 percent, and its albedo will then be expressed as 0.9.

ALLUVIAL DEPOSIT River deposits that include sand, silt, mud, gravel, and organic matter. They may also be rich in minerals. See also *alluvium*.

ALLUVIAL FAN A cone-shaped deposit of sediment built up by rivers or streams. Fans are typically found where steep-flowing watercourses, rich in deposits, emerge from mountains onto a plain. See also *alluvium*.

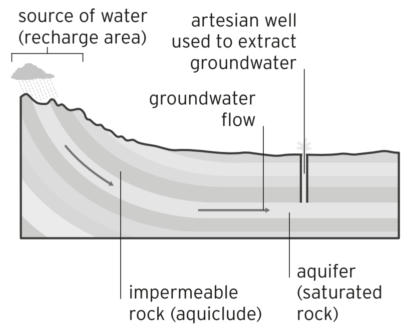
ALLUVIUM Any sedimentary material deposited by rivers, including sand, silt, mud, gravel, and organic matter. Any accumulation of alluvium is called an alluvial deposit. See also *alluvial deposit, alluvial fan*.

ANTICLINE A fold of stratified rocks in which the oldest strata (layers) are at the core. Anticlines result from massive horizontal compression. See also *fold* (panel), *syncline*.



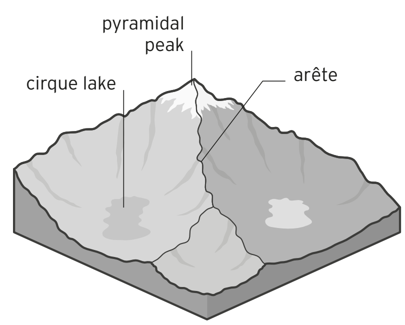
ANTICYCLONE ▲ A weather system in which atmospheric pressure is highest in the center. Wind circulates around the system in a clockwise direction in the Northern Hemisphere, counterclockwise in the Southern Hemisphere. See also *cyclone, pressure system*.

AQUIFER ▼ An underground layer of permeable rock from which groundwater can be extracted. See also *groundwater*.



ARCHIPELAGO A chain or cluster of islands. See also *island arc*.

ARÊTE ▼ A sharp-crested ridge separating two adjacent cirques. See also *cirque*.



ASTHENOSPHERE The viscous layer of the upper mantle immediately below the rigid lithosphere. Rock in this layer moves slowly in a solid state and is key to the movement of tectonic plates. See also *lithosphere* (panel), *mantle, tectonic plate*.

ASYMMETRICAL FOLD A fold whose axial plane is inclined, dipping in the same direction